

The California Sowing Depth Mini-Chart

Most seed failures are depth failures. Too deep and the seedling runs out of stored energy before it reaches light; too shallow and it dries out mid-germination. This chart covers the twenty crops most California gardens sow, with the spacing to thin to and how long to wait before declaring a row a do-over.

Twenty crops at a glance

Crop	Sow depth	Final spacing	Days to sprout
Tomato	1/4 in	18 to 36 in	5 to 10
Pepper	1/4 in	18 to 24 in	8 to 14
Eggplant	1/4 in	18 to 24 in	7 to 14
Lettuce	1/8 in (surface)	6 to 12 in	5 to 10
Spinach	1/2 in	3 to 6 in	6 to 12
Kale	1/4 to 1/2 in	12 to 18 in	5 to 10
Broccoli	1/4 to 1/2 in	18 in	5 to 10
Cabbage	1/4 to 1/2 in	12 to 18 in	5 to 10
Carrot	1/4 in	2 to 3 in	10 to 21
Beet	1/2 in	3 to 4 in	7 to 14
Radish	1/2 in	1 to 2 in	4 to 7
Onion (seed)	1/4 in	3 to 4 in	7 to 12
Pea	1 to 1.5 in	2 to 3 in	7 to 14
Bean (bush/pole)	1 to 1.5 in	3 to 6 in	7 to 10
Corn	1 to 1.5 in	8 to 12 in	5 to 10
Summer squash	1 in	24 to 36 in	5 to 10
Cucumber	1/2 to 1 in	12 in	5 to 10
Melon	1/2 to 1 in	24 to 36 in	5 to 10
Basil	1/4 in	8 to 12 in	5 to 10
Swiss chard	1/2 in	6 to 12 in	7 to 14

Days to sprout assume soil in the sweet spot for that crop. Cool spring soil can double every number in that column.

Four rules that replace a hundred seed packets

- **Sow about twice as deep as the seed is wide.** When in doubt, shallower beats deeper.
- **Lettuce needs light to germinate.** Press it into the surface and barely dust it with soil.
- **Big seeds direct sow; taproots stay put.** Beans, peas, corn, and squash resent transplanting, and carrots, beets, and radishes should never be moved.
- **Keep the seedbed evenly moist until sprouting.** One dry afternoon mid-germination can end a whole row. Water gently, daily if needed.

Want the timing to go with the depths?

Step-by-step seed starting and crop-by-crop California guides live at
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